

Life in the New Land

No matter what part of the globe immigrants came from, they faced many adjustments to a foreign—and often unfriendly—culture.

COOPERATION FOR SURVIVAL Once admitted to the country, immigrants faced many challenges. They had to find a place to live and get a job. They had to get along in daily life, while trying to learn an unfamiliar language and culture. Many immigrants tried to find people who shared their cultural values, practiced their religion, and spoke their native language. They settled in ethnic neighborhoods that served as life rafts for immigrants. In these communities, they could speak their native language. In New York City, for example, Jewish immigrants founded a theater that gave performances in Yiddish. This was the language spoken by Jews from central and eastern Europe. They even published newspapers in their own languages.

These ethnic neighborhoods also allowed immigrants to practice their own customs and traditions, which had often been passed down from generation to generation through families. People pooled their money to build churches or synagogues. They formed schools and social clubs to help preserve their customs. Ethnic neighborhoods also provided the comfort foods immigrants craved. These foods included Chinese dumplings, Italian pasta, Jewish latkes, and Polish perogies.

Immigrants also opened local shops and small businesses in these neighborhoods. Established business owners often helped new arrivals by offering credit and giving small loans. Such aid was important for newcomers because there were few commercial banks in immigrant communities.

Immigrants were committed to their own cultures, but they also tried to take on new identities. Many immigrants began to think of themselves as “hyphenated” Americans. They tried hard to fit in. However, these new Polish- and Italian- and Chinese-Americans felt increasing friction as they rubbed shoulders with people born and raised in the United States. Native-born people often disliked the immigrants’ unfamiliar customs and languages. Ironically, the descendants of earlier immigrants often viewed these new groups of immigrants as a threat to the American way of life.

SEEKING OPPORTUNITIES The majority of European immigrants settled in cities. Most were unskilled workers, so they took low-paying jobs in factories and mills. However, unskilled southern and eastern European immigrants were also recruited to work in the mining industry. These jobs usually paid the same low wages as factory jobs, but they were much more dangerous. Miners worked in dark, cramped conditions under the constant threat of cave-ins. Worse still was the presence of gases, such as methane, that could

Vocabulary

synagogue place of meeting for worship and religious instruction in the Jewish faith



This Italian immigrant sells fresh oysters from a cart on the streets of New York City.

kill if breathed in an enclosed space. On top of that, miners had to deal with pools of stagnant dirty water, coal dust, and swarms of rats. In the early 1900s, mine accidents killed three out of every ten miners in the United States each year.

In 1884 the Japanese government allowed Hawaiian planters to recruit Japanese workers. This caused a boost in Japanese emigration. By 1886 the majority of farm workers in the United States were of Asian descent. These workers included Chinese, Japanese, Indians, and Filipinos. Often they were barred from labor unions because of their race or status as unskilled workers. These immigrants had few protections and suffered terrible working conditions. They usually worked 16 hours a day in the hot sun. Low wages and unsanitary conditions in workers' camps made life for these immigrants even more difficult.

Reading Check
Summarize How did immigrants deal with challenges they faced?

Immigration Restrictions

Many native-born Americans thought of their country as a **melting pot**, a mixture of people of different cultures and races who blended together by abandoning their native languages and customs. Many new immigrants, however, did not wish to give up their cultural identities. As immigration increased, strong anti-immigrant feelings emerged.

THE RISE OF NATIVISM One response to the growth in immigration was **nativism**, or overt favoritism toward native-born Americans. Nativism gave rise to anti-immigrant groups and also led to a growing demand for immigration restrictions.

Many nativists believed that Anglo-Saxons—the Germanic ancestors of the English—were superior to other ethnic groups. These nativists did not object to immigrants from the “right” countries.

Prescott F. Hall, a founder in 1894 of the Immigration Restriction League, identified desirable immigrants as “British, German, and Scandinavian stock, historically free, energetic, progressive.” Nativists thought that problems were caused by immigrants from the “wrong” countries—“Slav, Latin, and Asiatic races, historically down-trodden . . . and stagnant.”

Nativists sometimes objected more to immigrants' religious beliefs than to their ethnic backgrounds. Many native-born Americans were Protestants and thought that Roman Catholic and Jewish immigrants would undermine the democratic institutions established by the country's Protestant founders. The American Protective Association, a nativist group founded in 1887, launched vicious anti-Catholic attacks, and many colleges, businesses, and social clubs refused to admit Jews.

In 1897 Congress, influenced by the Immigration Restriction League, passed a bill requiring a literacy test for immigrants. Those who could not read 40 words in English or their native language would be refused entry. Although President Cleveland vetoed the bill, it was a powerful statement of public sentiment. In 1917 a similar bill would be passed into law in spite of President Woodrow Wilson's veto.

Vocabulary
progressive favoring advancement toward better conditions or new ideas



Fear and resentment of Chinese immigrants sometimes resulted in mob attacks, like the one shown here.

Reading Check

Analyze Causes
How did nativism influence United States' policy on immigration?

ANTI-ASIAN SENTIMENT Nativism also found a foothold in the labor movement, particularly in the West, where native-born workers feared that jobs would go to Chinese immigrants, who would accept lower wages. The depression of 1873 intensified anti-Chinese sentiment in California. Work was scarce, and labor groups exerted political pressure on the government to restrict Asian immigration. The founder of the Workingmen's Party, Denis Kearney, headed the anti-Chinese movement in California. He made hundreds of speeches throughout the state, each ending with the message, "The Chinese must go!"

In 1882 Congress essentially slammed the door on Chinese immigration for ten years by passing the **Chinese Exclusion Act**. This act banned entry to all Chinese except students, teachers, merchants, tourists, and government officials. In 1892 Congress extended the law for another ten years. In 1902 Chinese immigration was restricted indefinitely; the law was not repealed until 1943.

THE GENTLEMEN'S AGREEMENT The fears that had led to anti-Chinese agitation were extended to Japanese and other Asian people in the early 1900s. In 1906 the local board of education in San Francisco segregated Japanese children by putting them in separate schools. When Japan raised an angry protest at this treatment of its emigrants, President Theodore Roosevelt worked out a deal. Under the **Gentlemen's Agreement** of 1907–1908, Japan's government agreed to limit emigration of unskilled workers to the United States in exchange for the repeal of the San Francisco segregation order.

Although doorways for immigrants had been all but closed to Asians on the West Coast, cities in the East and the Midwest teemed with European immigrants—and with urban opportunities and challenges.